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URL of this page: https://medlineplus.gov/gerd.html

GERD

Also called: Gastroesophageal reflux disease

What is GERD?

Sometimes, after eating a large meal or lying down too soon after eating, you might feel acid coming up into your throat. This is called gastroesophageal reflux (GER). It happens when the muscle at the end of your esophagus (the tube that carries food from your mouth to your stomach) doesn't close properly. Stomach contents can then move back up and irritate the esophagus.

Having reflux occasionally is common. But if you have symptoms two or more times a week or if they cause damage to the lining of your esophagus, you may have gastroesophageal reflux disease (GERD). GERD is a chronic (long-lasting) condition that can cause discomfort and, over time, lead to other health problems.

Anyone can have GERD, including infants [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxininfants.html] and children [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxinchildren.html] .

What causes GERD?

GERD can happen when the muscle at the bottom of your esophagus becomes weak or relaxes at the wrong time. You are more likely to have GERD if you:

- Are overweight or have obesity [https://medlineplus.gov/obesity.html]
- Are pregnant [https://medlineplus.gov/pregnancy.html]
- Smoke [https://medlineplus.gov/smoking.html] or are around secondhand smoke [https://medlineplus.gov/secondhandsmoke.html]
- Have a hiatal hernia [https://medlineplus.gov/hiatalhernia.html] (when part of the stomach pushes up into the chest)

Certain foods, drinks, or medicines can also make GERD worse.

What are common symptoms of GERD?

The most common symptom of GERD is heartburn [https://medlineplus.gov/heartburn.html] . This is a burning feeling in your chest or throat. You can also have GERD without having heartburn. Other symptoms may include:

- Tasting acid or food in the back of your mouth
- A dry cough [https://medlineplus.gov/cough.html] or hoarse voice
- Asthma [https://medlineplus.gov/asthma.html] -like symptoms
- Trouble swallowing [https://medlineplus.gov/swallowingdisorders.html]

Get medical help right away if you have chest pain [https://medlineplus.gov/chestpain.html] with shortness of breath [https://medlineplus.gov/breathingproblems.html] , or pain in your jaw or arm. These can be signs of a heart problem.

How is GERD diagnosed?

Your health care provider will ask about your symptoms and medical history. They may recommend tests such as:

- **Upper GI** endoscopy [https://medlineplus.gov/endoscopy.html] to look at the esophagus and stomach lining with a tiny camera.
- Biopsy [https://medlineplus.gov/biopsy.html] to check a small tissue sample.
- X-Ray [https://medlineplus.gov/xrays.html] to take pictures of the upper digestive system.
- **Esophageal pH test** to measure how often acid backs up the esophagus and how long the acid stays there.
- **Esophageal manometry** to check how well your esophagus moves food when you swallow.
- **Transnasal esophagoscopy** to look for damage to the esophagus by using a small tube with a camera.

How is GERD treated?

Most people can manage GERD with lifestyle changes and medicine. In rare cases, surgery is needed.

Lifestyle changes can include:

- Eating smaller meals and avoiding lying down for at least 2-3 hours after eating
- Avoiding foods that trigger symptoms, such as spicy foods, chocolate, caffeine, or fatty foods
- Losing weight [https://medlineplus.gov/weightcontrol.html] if needed
- Raising the head of your bed
- Quitting smoking [https://medlineplus.gov/quittingsmoking.html]

Medicines can include:

- Over-the-counter medicines [https://medlineplus.gov/overthecountermedicines.html] , such as antacids
- Prescription medicines

If not treated, GERD can cause problems like inflammation of the esophagus [https://medlineplus.gov/esophagusdisorders.html] , scarring, or changes in the tissue lining (Barrett's esophagus). It can also worsen asthma or cause chronic (long-term) cough or hoarseness.

Can GERD be prevented?

You may be able to improve symptoms of GERD by:

- Avoiding alcohol [https://medlineplus.gov/alcohol.html] and trigger foods
- Eating smaller meals
- Not eating close to bedtime
- Wearing loose-fitting clothes
- Sleeping on your left side or raising the head of your bed
- Maintaining a healthy weight

NIH: National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases

Start Here

- Acid Reflux (GER and GERD) in Adults [https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/digestive-diseases/acid-reflux-ger-gerd-adults] (National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/informacion-de-la-salud/enfermedades-digestivas/reflujo-gastrico-rge-enfermedad-por-reflujo-gastroesofagico-erge-adultos]
- Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease (GERD) [https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/gerd/symptoms-causes/syc-20361940?p=1] (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)

Symptoms

- Is It Really GERD? [https://www.health.harvard.edu/diseases-and-conditions/is-it-really-gerd] (Harvard Medical School)

Diagnosis and Tests

- Barium Swallow [https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/barium-swallow/] (National Library of Medicine)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/pruebas-de-laboratorio/transito-esofagogastroduodenal/]
- Esophageal pH Test [https://medlineplus.gov/lab-tests/esophageal-ph-test/] (National Library of Medicine)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/pruebas-de-laboratorio/prueba-de-ph-esofagico/]
- pH Impedance Study [https://gikids.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/03/pH-Study-Brochure-English-FINAL-1.pdf] (North American Society for Pediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition) - **PDF**
- Upper GI -- Esophagram -- Barium Swallow [https://www.radiologyinfo.org/en/info/uppergi] (American College of Radiology; Radiological Society of North America)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.radiologyinfo.org/es/info/uppergi]
- Upper GI Endoscopy [https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/diagnostic-tests/upper-gi-endoscopy] (National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/informacion-de-la-salud/pruebas-diagnosticas/endoscopia-gastrointestinal-superior?dkrd=/health-information/informacion-de-la-salud/pruebas-diagnosticas/endoscopia-esofagogastroduodenal]

Treatments and Therapies

- Antacids and Acid Reducers: OTC Relief for Heartburn and Acid Reflux [https://familydoctor.org/antacids-and-acid-reducers-otc-relief-for-heartburn-and-acid-reflux/] (American Academy of Family Physicians)
- Feeling the Burn? Options for Acid Reflux [https://newsinhealth.nih.gov/2018/11/feeling-burn] (National Institutes of Health)
  Also in Spanish [https://salud.nih.gov/recursos-de-salud/nih-noticias-de-salud/sintiendo-el-ardor]
- Fundoplication (For Children) [https://gikids.org/tests-procedures/fundoplication/] (North American Society for Pediatric Gastroenterology, Hepatology and Nutrition)
  Also in Spanish [https://gikids.org/fundoplication/?lang=es]
- Gastroesophageal reflux - series [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/presentations/100181_1.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/esp_presentations/100181_1.htm]

Related Issues

- Esophageal Spasms [https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/esophageal-spasms/symptoms-causes/syc-20372250?p=1] (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.mayoclinic.org/es/diseases-conditions/esophageal-spasms/symptoms-causes/syc-20372250?p=1]

- Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease [https://www.aaaai.org/conditions-treatments/related-conditions/gastroesophageal-reflux-disease] (American Academy of Allergy, Asthma, and Immunology)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.aaaai.org/conditions-treatments/afecciones-y-tratamientos/afecciones-relacionadas/enfermedad-de-reflujo-gastroesofagico-(erg)]
- GERD: Can Certain Medications Make It Worse? [https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/gerd/expert-answers/heartburn-gerd/faq-20058535?p=1] (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.mayoclinic.org/es/diseases-conditions/gerd/expert-answers/heartburn-gerd/faq-20058535?p=1]
- Indigestion [https://familydoctor.org/condition/indigestion/] (American Academy of Family Physicians)
- Non-Cardiac Chest Pain [https://gi.org/topics/non-cardiac-chest-pain/] (American College of Gastroenterology)
- Warning: Aspirin-Containing Antacid Medicines Can Cause Bleeding [https://www.fda.gov/consumers/consumer-updates/warning-aspirin-containing-antacid-medicines-can-cause-bleeding] (Food and Drug Administration)
  Also in Spanish [https://www.fda.gov/consumers/articulos-para-el-consumidor-en-espanol/advertencia-los-antiacidos-que-contienen-aspirina-pueden-causar-sangrado]

Test Your Knowledge

- Test Your GERD Knowledge [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/quiz/000265_7.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/quiz/000265_67.htm]

Clinical Trials

- ClinicalTrials.gov: Gastroesophageal Reflux [https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?cond=%22Gastroesophageal+Reflux%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec] NIH (National Institutes of Health)

Journal Articles

References and abstracts from MEDLINE/PubMed (National Library of Medicine)

- Article: Adjunctive probiotic therapy sustains symptom relief in gastroesophageal reflux disease through... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41609355]
- Article: Hewei Jiangni recipe improved the quality of life in patients with... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41015809]
- Article: Comparative efficacy of sleeve gastrectomy with fundoplication versus standard sleeve gastrectomy... [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/40919661]
- GERD -- see more articles [https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/?term=%22Gastroesophageal+Reflux%22%5Bmajr%3Anoexp%5D+AND+humans%5Bmh%5D+AND+english%5Bla%5D+AND+%22last+1+Year%22+%5Bedat%5D+AND+%28patient+education+handout%5Bpt%5D+OR+guideline%5Bpt%5D+OR+clinical+trial%5Bpt%5D%29++NOT+%28letter%5Bpt%5D+OR+case+reports%5Bpt%5D+OR+editorial%5Bpt%5D+OR+comment%5Bpt%5D%29+AND+free+full+text%5Bsb%5D+]

Find an Expert

- American College of Gastroenterology [https://gi.org]
- ASGE: Find a Doctor [https://www.asge.org/find-a-doctor-results] (American Society for Gastrointestinal Endoscopy)
- Find a Gastroenterologist (GI Doctor) [https://gi.org/patients/find-a-gastroenterologist/] (American College of Gastroenterology)
- Find a SAGES Surgeon [https://www.sages.org/public-search/] (Society of American Gastrointestinal and Endoscopic Surgeons)
- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases [https://www.niddk.nih.gov] NIH

Children

- Reflux in Children: MedlinePlus Health Topic [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxinchildren.html]
  (National Library of Medicine)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/refluxinchildren.html]
- Reflux in Infants: MedlinePlus Health Topic [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxininfants.html]
  (National Library of Medicine)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/refluxininfants.html]

Teenagers

- Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease (GERD) (For Teens) [https://kidshealth.org/en/teens/gerd.html]
  (Nemours Foundation)
  Also in Spanish [https://kidshealth.org/es/teens/gerd.html]

Patient Handouts

- Anti-reflux surgery [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/002925.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/article/002925.htm]
- Bland diet [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000068.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000068.htm]
- Gastroesophageal reflux - discharge [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000197.htm]
  (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000197.htm]
- Gastroesophageal reflux disease [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/000265.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/article/000265.htm]
- Swallowing problems [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000065.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000065.htm]
- Taking antacids [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000198.htm] (Medical Encyclopedia)
  Also in Spanish [https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000198.htm]

MEDICAL ENCYCLOPEDIA

Anti-reflux surgery [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/002925.htm]

Anti-reflux surgery - children [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/007401.htm]

Anti-reflux surgery - children - discharge [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000289.htm]

Anti-reflux surgery - discharge [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000160.htm]

Bernstein test [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/003897.htm]

Bland diet [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000068.htm]

Esophageal manometry [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/003884.htm]

Esophageal pH monitoring [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/003401.htm]

Esophagitis [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/001153.htm]

Gastroesophageal reflux - discharge [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000197.htm]

Gastroesophageal reflux - series [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/presentations/100181_1.htm]

Gastroesophageal reflux disease [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/000265.htm]

Gastroesophageal reflux disease - children [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/007688.htm]

Lower esophageal ring [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/000208.htm]

Swallowing problems [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000065.htm]

Taking antacids [https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000198.htm]

Related Health Topics

Esophagus Disorders [https://medlineplus.gov/esophagusdisorders.html]

Heartburn [https://medlineplus.gov/heartburn.html]

Hiatal Hernia [https://medlineplus.gov/hiatalhernia.html]

Reflux in Children [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxinchildren.html]

Reflux in Infants [https://medlineplus.gov/refluxininfants.html]

National Institutes of Health

The primary NIH organization for research on *GERD* is the National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases [https://www.niddk.nih.gov]

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Last updated November 24, 2025